similar to Vedanta. About Akbar's visit in 1601, Jahangir wrote that 'he often mentioned it with fondness'. Akbar finally reached Fatehpur Sikri in August 1601 where he spent eleven days in the company of his mother and Salima Sultan Begum before moving to Agra.

Akbar was accompanied back to Agra by the two Jesuit priests, Xavier and Pignero, who began immediately and persistently petitioning the Padshah for a written farman stating that he allowed his subjects the freedom to convert to Christianity. When the Jesuits presented themselves to Akbar in the palace at Agra, they found the Padshah surrounded by some 150 dishes full of gold pieces, which he had had made. Having examined the coins, he had them tied up in bags and deposited in the treasury. Agra Fort and all its elites were now sparkling with the lustre of what would become a Mughal obsession—precious stones. The royal kar khanas now included a bustling jewellery department, and unusual and beautiful stones from all corners of the empire were sent to Agra where they would be cut, polished, and mounted and sent to court where they were used for adornment. The Padshah and his courtiers wore them as turban decorations, necklaces, earrings, armbands, bracelets, rings and to decorate the hilt of swords and patkas. Akbar gave them as gifts to favoured courtiers, and to his wives, and distributed them to the poor on the occasion of his tuladan or that of his sons'. The stones were found everywhere…

> on royal thrones encrusted with rubies, emeralds, and diamonds; on the walls and ceilings of the imperial buildings, which gleam with inlaid jade, amethyst, turquoise and mother of pearl.

The Jesuits brought with them presents which were quite as valuable in Akbar's eyes: two paintings, one a portrait of Albuquerque, and the other of the Portuguese Viceroy, Ayres de Saldagna, which the Padshah was very pleased with. Akbar listened to the Jesuits' request and granted their wish for a written farman and 'for some days little else was talked of at the court' wrote the Jesuits, 'for never before had such a dispensation been granted in a (Muslim) country'. The most vociferous voice of opposition was that of Mirza Aziz Koka and uneasy rumours slipped along the corridors of the palace to the effect that Akbar was no longer a practising Muslim.

The Padshah asked the priests to translate into Persian the story of the life of Christ, which Pignero was able to do. Called the *Mirat al-Quds* (The Mirror of Purity), the book was full of the miracles and teachings of Christ,